specializing in hernia surgery for close to two decades and has developed some new repair techniques in recent years that have considerably improved the recovery process. She immediately makes her patients feel at ease and she was quick to assure me that there was no chance of recurrence once she had operated on me. To my delight she was proved right.

I had the first operation on 14 August and must say the pain was perfectly bearable. I had asked Dr Muschaweck if both sides of the groin could be done on the same day but was told that it wasn't feasible because there would be far too much pain. Anjali hadn't been able to accompany me initially because of Sara's examinations, but she joined me on the evening of the 14th and I underwent my second operation on the morning of the 15th. I had insisted on having the two operations on consecutive days to cut down the recovery time, in the hope of getting fit for the Australian Test series. This time the pain was excruciating. Cleaning myself was quite an ordeal because of the serious pain in my abdomen and I wasn't able to eat a thing. I was given a laxative and this, a sweet sugar syrup with a very nice taste, was the only thing I enjoyed having that night! I could hardly sleep with all the pain and was looking forward to getting back home.

It was an important operation and one that helped prolong my cricket career. It also draws attention to the lack of specialized sports science centres in India at that time. While I could afford to go to Munich and get myself treated by the best experts in the world, for other Indian athletes it might not always have been feasible.

I certainly knew I'd had a serious operation afterwards. I remember leaving the clinic on 16 August in a wheelchair because I felt dizzy every time I tried to stand. I also remember telling Anjali that I was about to faint when standing at the check-in counter at the airport and Anjali rushing to help. After landing in Mumbai, my friend Faisal Momen picked me up and for the first time in my life I asked him to drive as slowly as possible. I was frantically monitoring the road and if I spotted a speed bump I would lift myself a little with my hands to avoid jarring my abdomen.

As soon as I got home Anjali told the kids that for the time being they wouldn't be able to give their father a hug. At that time, Arjun used to like play-fighting with me and I had to show him the bandages to make him understand that I was just too unwell. It was a difficult time for us